



IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Ealing comedy

DIRECTOR

Robert Hamer

WRITERS

**Robert Hamer
with John Dighton**

STARS

Alec Guinness, Dennis Price, Joan Greenwood, Valerie Hobson

BEFORE

1942 *Went the Day Well?* is one of the first successful movies made at Ealing Studios.

1947 *It Always Rains on a Sunday* is the first of Robert Hamer's three Ealing movies.

AFTER

1951 *The Lavender Hill Mob* features Alec Guinness as a mousy clerk who becomes a criminal mastermind.

1957 *Barnacle Bill* is the last of the Ealing comedies. Alec Guinness plays multiple roles.

IT IS SO DIFFICULT TO MAKE A NEAT JOB OF KILLING PEOPLE WITH WHOM ONE IS NOT ON FRIENDLY TERMS

KIND HEARTS AND CORONETS / 1949

Kind Hearts and Coronets is one of a series of British comedies that came out of the Ealing Studios in London between 1947 and 1957. Starring Alec Guinness as all eight members of the D'Ascoyne family, each of whom falls victim to a gentleman murderer, the movie has the urbane harm and light with characteristic of the Ealing style. The plot centers on the rise of Louis Mazzini (Dennis Price), who is determined to avenge his mother for the shabby treatment she received at the hands of the D'Ascoyne family. One by one, he plots to remove all family members

that stand between him and the D'Ascoyne fortune and dukedom. His murder spree begins with the arrogant young Ascoyne D'Ascoyne, and ends with Lord Ascoyne.

Comic killings

Guinness is the star of the movie, and each of his absurd characters is so sharply drawn that they are instantly delineated, to great comic effect. But Guinness is matched by the movie's "straight man," Price. As Mazzini, he is the epitome of manners, exhibiting such courtesy and aplomb that the audience feels a sense of glee as he dispatches each D'Ascoyne in turn.

Alec Guinness Actor

Sir Alec Guinness was one of the great British actors of the last century, noted for his subtle gentlemanly manner. Born in 1914 in London, he started life as an advertising copywriter, before taking up stage acting. He became acclaimed for his Shakespearean roles, and by 1950 was a celebrated actor of the London stage. He began his screen career with a series of Ealing comedies before working with director David Lean on

more serious movies, winning an Oscar for his performance in *The Bridge on the River Kwai*. Playing Obi-Wan Kenobi in the *Star Wars* movies made him hugely famous in the 1980s. He died in 2000 at 86.

Key movies

1949 *Kind Hearts and Coronets*
1955 *The Ladykillers*
1957 *Bridge on the River Kwai*
1965 *Doctor Zhivago*